Explaining Death to the Dog

By Susan Perabo

NARRATOR: **(Pgs 77-84)** After the baby died, I found it imperative that my German shepherd Stu understand and accept the concept of death. The first week wasn't so bad, what with all our friends and relatives around, smothering Stu with affection. And Todd was home from work that week, dumping well-meaning casseroles accidentally-on-purpose onto the kitchen floor for Stu to indulge in. So Stu didn't notice the absence so much, didn't seem to. He trotted around the house happily, oblivious to the fact that the baby, who he had had a big hand in raising, was missing.

Then the party ended. Guests cried the last of their tears at my front door, said "What a waste" for the thousandth and final time, and made their separate ways back to their separate lives, lives that sailed along quite smoothly despite the absence of the infant whom they had been mourning for a good seven or eight days.

Todd went back to work; packed up his briefcase and kissed me good-bye. He nearly tripped over Stu in his rush to get out of the house. He wanted away, wanted to get busy again. Stu and I stood at the window and watched him drive away. Stu looked up at me and then back at the empty driveway. He lay down on the floor in front of the window. I sat next to him and rubbed his stomach. He sighed.

INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR: What to do with the baby dead? No diapers, no screaming, no feeding. What had I done before the baby? I had been pregnant. Pregnant for longer than she had been alive. And what had I done before I got pregnant? I tried to remember. I supposed I had cleaned the house. Cooked. Taken Stu to the park. It didn't seem like it could have been nearly enough to take up a whole day. In the afternoon I made myself a sandwich from one of the

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two whole hams that were still in the refrigerator and sat in front of the television. I waited for Stu, waited for him to emerge from wherever he was sleeping, jingling and jangling his way to a possible meal. The house was quiet. Still, very still. The morning the baby died Todd shook me awake to the stillness and said, "Listen, she's sleeping ... "

I set my sandwich on the coffee table and got up to look for Stu. I called him a few times. Nothing. I walked through the house, from room to room. I found him upstairs, in the baby's room. The room was empty, except for one chair. Todd and the relatives had cleaned it out the day of the funeral because they said it was just too sad to look at. They stashed the crib in the back of a stranger's car and carted it away, hid the dolls and mobiles with the cobwebs in the basement. Then Todd's mother said the room looked so bare, so she had taken a chair from our bedroom and set it by the window. It looked unnatural by itself in the baby's room. Worse than bare. Just awkward.

Stu was lying in the middle of the empty room. His ears were back and his eyes open. He didn't raise his head when I came in. He just followed me with his eyes. *(to the dog)* Stu. Stu, what the hell are you doing? *(to the audience)* He looked like he had eaten too much casserole, was what it was, looked like he might toss his canine cookies at any moment. He stood up lazily. He walked in circles around the room. You could tell he was looking for the baby.

(to the dog) No. *(patting his head)* No more baby. Baby's gone. No baby. *(to the audience)* He looked at me with the universal blank dog look. He had no idea what I was talking about. It was then that I realized the impossibility of the situation. It wasn't even like trying to explain death to a child. The dog simply couldn't understand the language. He had a brain the size of a walnut and all he knew was that the baby wasn't where she was supposed to be. I imagined it must be even worse than knowing the baby was dead. At least Todd had been able to logically spell it out for me that morning to get me to stop shaking her and trying to wake her up, hold the little girl up in my face, point to the chest. NO BREATHING.

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It was then I decided that I needed to teach Stu about death, whatever the cost. I figured he had a right to know, being a member of the family.

(to the dog) Come on, boy. *(to the audience)* On the coffee table we had a book. A big *Life* magazine book. *Best of Life,* something like that. I gave Stu part of my ham sandwich to lure him up on the couch with me. I opened the book out on the coffee table, paged through it, looking for the sixties, the best lesson of death on film. I turned the dog's head toward the contorted face of Lee Harvey Oswald, and the man behind him, a man whose name they never mentioned, looking like he might jump right out of his skin from the shock of it. Oswald was holding his stomach, hadn't even hit the floor.

(to the dog) Dead. Stu, it's dead. *(to the audience)* Stu didn't seem to see the picture. He looked at the book, sure, but there was nothing in his eyes that said that he saw the proverbial farm being bought. The way he looked at it, it could have been a picture of a rolling wheat field. I turned the page, looking for something bigger, and found a two-page spread from Memphis, 1968, the man dead on the balcony, people pointing out into the sky. It was big; you couldn't miss it.

(to the dog) Death. No more. *(to the audience)* Again Stu glanced at the picture, then back at my ham sandwich. I jabbed my finger on Martin Luther King, Jr., held the picture up in Stu's face, and still his eyes didn't focus on it. What was I expecting? I don't know. If Todd had been there he would have clapped the book shut and told me the dog didn't know what the hell was going on and he'd be over it in a day and a half anyway. But Todd was gone. Strange things happen when you're alone in the house with pets all day . . .

In the middle of the night I woke up and heard the baby crying. I sat up and reached for my glasses before I remembered. It was not a staggering thing. It washed over me slowly, the way you remember what day it is when you wake up in the morning. I looked at Todd lying on his stomach next to me, the side of his face pressed to the pillow, his mouth open. The first week it was him who couldn't sleep. I'd open my eyes and he'd be sitting up in bed, his back against the wall, staring into space. The minister had come by and Todd told him about

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not being able to sleep. The minister said it was probably guilt, thinking that if he'd been awake when the baby started dying he could have done something about it. After that I guess Todd became comfortable with the guilt, because he didn't sit up nights anymore.

Todd? . . . Todd? *(to the audience)* I didn't have the courage to touch him, to wake him up and force him to share the grief, to try to explain to me why I might have heard the baby crying when the baby had been dead for over a week. I lay back down next to him and started thinking about the simplicity of a dog's mind. I tried to think of a way to explain to Stu just exactly what was going on.

The morning was cool and dark. It was May and the natural order of things said it should have been warm and bright. But the natural order of things was wrong, so it was ugly out. Todd sat at breakfast and looked at the newspaper in much the same way Stu had looked at the coffee table book. His spoon went from the cereal bowl to his mouth without being led by anything but habit. I stared at him and he didn't even notice.

NARRATOR: *(to Todd)* I think Stu misses the baby.

TODD: *(looking up from the paper, his mouth open and his eyes empty.* What?

NARRATOR: Yesterday he was lying in her room.

TODD: Close the door.

NARRATOR: I was thinking. I was trying to figure out how to get it across to him that she's not coming back.

TODD: Why would you think something like that?

NARRATOR: I just thought it was interesting. I wondered how dogs understand those kinds of things.

TODD: What are you doing today? Why don't you call somebody for lunch?

NARRATOR: No one wants to have lunch with me.

TODD: *(sighing)* We'll go out tonight, then.

NARRATOR: *(to the audience)* But he wasn't even looking at me. He was looking over my shoulder out the back door, out into the grayness that was passing itself off as morning.

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I decided I would go ahead and take Stu to the park, force him down the slide for a good laugh, spin us both around on the merry-go-round just for a change of pace. There would be no baby carriage to drag through the sand, no need to worry about it slipping from my grip and careening down a hill into the creek. The park was different with no baby. It seemed much safer.

Then we found the squirrel. Stu walked right past it, didn't even notice, but I saw it. It was lying on its side in the grass. Its mouth was open, its eyes empty holes. Other than that it was fine. Perfectly whole, not the work of a cat or a child with a BB gun.

(to the dog) Stu. Stu, come here baby. *(to the audience)* He stopped, turned back, then trotted to where I was kneeling on the ground. He saw the squirrel and stopped for a second. He looked at me. I reached out to touch the squirrel and Stu took a step back. Its fur was damp and brittle. Stu walked up to the squirrel, then turned his head away and looked at me like I had gotten him into something he wasn't near ready for. A fly landed on the squirrel's head and crawled into the empty eye socket.

(to the dog) Stu. This is important. *(takes his head and turns it toward the rodent, pushing his nose closer to the body)* The squirrel's dead. You understand? *(to the audience)* Squirrels, I could hear Stu thinking. I chase these things. This squirrel is not running. Stu backed away from the animal. I tried to hold on to him but he pulled me backward and I fell from my knees onto the wet grass. Stu ran in circles around me, afraid he was in trouble . . . So we were going to go out for dinner. Todd came home and sat on the couch in a heap. His tie was askew and his hair mussed. I asked him if he had a bad day and he said he was just a little tired. *(to Todd)* Does that mean we're not going to dinner?

TODD: *(wearily)* I didn't say that. I didn't say we weren't going out. *(pause)* Where do you want to go?

NARRATOR: We could go someplace fancy. We haven't been someplace fancy in a long time.

TODD: *(noticing the dog)* What's up with him?

NARRATOR: I told you. He's confused.

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TODD: He's confused. The ***dog*** is confused. *(shakes his head sadly)*

NARRATOR: *(to the audience)* I was trying to think of a way to make a case for how confused Stu really was, but Todd didn't seem receptive to the idea.

TODD: *(loosening his tie)* Let me change. We'll go out. I just have to get out of these clothes.

NARRATOR: *(to the audience)* I sat on the couch with Stu and waited. Stu put his head on my thigh and looked up at me. I wanted to do something for him, take him out to dinner with us to get his mind off the mystery of the missing baby. We sat there for a few minutes. I couldn't hear any noises coming from the bedroom, so I got up and went down the hallway. I looked in the door and saw Todd sitting on the edge of the bed. He was banging the side of his head, crying while he was doing it. Actually he wasn't really crying. He was more making little howling noises with his throat. And he just kept whacking himself on the head.

I went back into the living room. I had a desire to get Stu off the couch and give him a push toward the bedroom, so he could stumble upon Todd and see what the death thing was all about, but I didn't have the heart . . .

I woke again in the middle of the night, but I didn't hear any crying. I got out of bed anyway and went into the baby's room. Stu hopped up and followed me, hopefully, but the room was still empty except for the chair by the window. Still, the dog wandered around, sniffing out the emptiness, the way he had the day before, and the day before that, and the way I realized he probably would for quite a while. I sat down in the chair by the window.

Everything was quiet, and I thought of saying to Stu that that was it, that was death, the quiet. But Stu was still sniffing around the room, trying to pick up the scent of the baby, and I realized he would never understand death. All he would come to understand was that the baby was not coming back.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier – MS
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